

Dear Professor Fredericks,

*The book was long, and difficult to read, and Klaus became more and more tired as the night wore on. Occasionally his eyes would close. He found himself reading the same sentence over and over. He found himself reading the same sentence over and over. He found himself reading the same sentence over and over. — Lemony Snicket, The Bad Beginning*

Since I was a child, I've always struggled with reading and writing. Like shoveling sand through a strainer, I watched it pool and well in my hands and then pour straight through, pudding at the bottom as undisturbed as before. I would scan the same text over and over, reading and rereading the same paragraphs, lines, and words to find my mind exhausted and my eyes hovering at the top of the same text again. *I need to focus harder*, I would think — *I need to read it faster, -read it again, -understand it better*; sand falling through the sieve. "It was frustrating" is what I didn't have the words to describe when I was younger. It was infuriating. This semester marks my third attempt at English 105, each enrollment reflecting its corresponding year, highlighting my experience and lessons I've learned during my undergraduate degree. From the habits of mind, the two that resonated most with me are "Thinking about your thinking" and "Creating, imagining, and innovating," showing my personal growth and identity in this English 105 course and my undergraduate degree.

"Thinking about your thinking" to me is metacognition. It's self-analysis, and more importantly, redirection and growth. This concept always petrified me as a kid — the existentialism, self-esteem, and anxiety felt devastating. I was a nihilist, angry at the world for my conception, my upbringing, my family, the kids who bullied me in school, and the teachers

who thought I was too much effort for their time. It was hollowing, so I blocked it out and pushed forward. I moved to college, learning and moving fast: landing a tech job at 18, getting married and divorced, living homeless in an RV, crashing two cars, and buying two more. Research applying machine learning in computational cognitive science, full-time work in DevOps and full-stack development, and completing a nine-course semester after fast-tracking my degree. And now I find myself again at the top of the page, a freshman in my master's next semester, wondering if all I've been doing is pushing sand through a sieve. Why am I here? Was all of the work I put in just a form of distraction?

This semester has been a chance for me to reflect on my thinking, identify who I want to be, and where I want to go. Instead of just pushing forward, I stopped to think, *where am I going and why? Why am I doing research? Why am I working here? Why am I trying so hard in my degree and pursuing a master's?* And my answer to all of the previous: because I want to; because it's fun for me and I look forward to it; because it makes me feel fulfilled and happy doing what I do. Doing research that assumes similarities between robots and humans makes a sort of cynical assumption about inhumanity towards sentience, but also about beauty and understanding. I am the sum of the choices I've made in my life, and I am the superposition of all of the choices I will make in the future. This is to say, not so overimportantly, that my identity is both my past and what I choose to do in the future. If I want to learn how to cook, go for it — I'm a cook now. If I want to learn to sing? — Sure, that's what I am. If I want to crush the word count on a bonus assignment created to boost the grades of freshmen, because I've got something to say? So my response to myself about who I am is this: I'm Avinh. I am someone who has struggled, who's made mistakes and who's succeeded beyond gratitude, who's tried my hardest in everything I did, who's temperamental at times, whose cats are the most

awesome guys ever, whose partner I adore, and whose identity has been hardened, calloused, and refined into the person I am today by the lived experiences I have and the direction I choose to take it.

This reflects my voice in writing this semester. I've struggled with writing my whole life, and with each time, I have gotten better. Before this Spring 2026 English 105 course, when I would have read, "write three paragraphs", I would think, *push sand, fill the hole*. It was a criterion to fill the way I thought my professor wanted it to be: concise, perfectly formatted, with a topic sentence, background, quote, analysis, and conclusion. To be fair, I've been just fine filling out the rubric to a tee, but now I understand that there is more to it. The assignment is to show growth, tell a story, write from me to you — not filling paragraphs or quotas. "Thinking about your thinking" to me is growth through hardship. I think, I struggle, I change my approach, and I grow. In my freshman year of English, I tried, I failed, and I grew; My sophomore year, I tried again, I grew further; and my junior year now, I understand that I will continue to grow and fail to succeed. Like my academic journey has led me to growth and identity, the evolution of my writing has coincided, improving and establishing my voice. And with this growth, I lead into my second habit of mind-

"Creating, imagining, and innovating" are my steps for the future. This course (and courses I have previously failed to see) taught me the creative freedom afforded by writing. This semester has taught me intent and direction. And, this degree has taught me grit and confidence. And all of these, including the writing in this course, have taught me my identity and voice. Writing not to fill a rubric, but my actual speaking voice and my true thoughts and feelings; not pushing sand, but building a sand castle. With the lessons I've learned and the identity I built from them, I can create something that is completely and originally me. As I

move into my master's, I am confident in the person that I have grown to be. Maybe I'll publish a dozen papers with my PI, or make a shit ton of money in tech. Maybe I'll crash out and own a farm, who knows —, but I'll do it unapologetically myself.

*He does not always remain bent over the pages; he often leans back and closes his eyes over a line he has been reading again, and its meaning spreads through his blood. — Rainer Maria Rilke*

Sincerely,

Avinh Huynh

P.S: My master's is at SFSU, so say hi!